

Wish / If Only

B2 · Upper-Intermediate · Express regret and unreal wishes about the present and the past.

"Wish" and "if only" (a stronger, more emotional version of wish) let you express that reality is different from what you want — in the present, or looking back at the past.

Rules

a) Present wish — wish/if only + past simple

- I wish I had more free time. (I don't have much now)
- If only I spoke French. (I don't speak French)

b) Past regret — wish/if only + past perfect

- I wish I had studied harder. (I didn't, and now I regret it)
- If only I hadn't said that. (I did say it, and I regret it)

c) Complaint about someone's behavior — wish + would

- I wish you would stop interrupting me. (a complaint/request for change, annoyance)

Not used for yourself: "I wish I would..." isn't standard — use "I wish I could" or "I wish I did/had."

Examples

- I wish I had more free time.
- If only I spoke French.
- I wish I had studied harder.
- If only I hadn't said that.
- I wish you would stop interrupting me.
- She wishes she could travel more.

Common Mistakes

✗ I wish I have more time.

✓ I wish I had more time.

A present wish needs the past simple form (had), not the present.

× I wish I studied harder. (regretting a past choice)

✓ I wish I had studied harder.

A past regret needs the past perfect (had studied), not the simple past.

× I wish I would speak French.

✓ I wish I spoke French. / I wish I could speak French.

"Wish + would" isn't used for your own ability/state — use the past simple or "could" instead.

× I wish you stop interrupting me.

✓ I wish you would stop interrupting me.

A complaint about someone else's behavior needs "wish + would."

Summary

- Wish/if only + past simple = a present wish (reality is different now).
- Wish/if only + past perfect = a past regret.
- Wish + would = a complaint about someone else's behavior — not used for yourself.

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